READING A CHINESE CLASSIC ON ANCIENT MEDICINE: THE INNER CANONS OF THE YELLOW EMPEROR 黄帝内经

GEC1044/GEH1070 Tutorial 1

Points to note

- Attendance will be marked during all tutorial sessions.
- Participation marks will be awarded for each student.
- Your absence can only be excused with reasons such as: valid medical certificate; official letter of excuse from NUS Faculty/Department or National Service (NS) obligations.
- Students MUST adhere to the tutorial timeslots that you have registered for; attendance / participation **won't be counted** if you attend another timeslot without prior approval.

A Quick Recap……

- **Authorship**

Unknown.

A compilation of several fragmentary texts of several authors.

- **Date of completion**

Exact time unknown. Book was first written no earlier than 4th century B.C. and completed in 3rd century A.D.)

The present edition of the text (that we are using) reached its final form by the 11th century A.D.

- **The structure of the *Huangdi neijing***

Divided into two parts:

Su wen 素問 (Basic Questions)— 9 *juan* 卷 (volumes)

Su wen— Anatomy, Physiology, and Therapy

Ling shu 灵枢 (Spiritual Pivot)— 9 *juan*

Ling shu— Meridian network (*jingmai* 经脉) and Acupoints (*xuewei* 穴位)



"The formation of vessel theory (*mai li* 脉理) and of the yin-yang (阴阳) and five-agents (*wu xing* 五行) doctrines of systematic correspondence was part of a wide-ranging intellectual movement in Chinese natural philosophy whose beginnings can be seen in the 4th and 3rd centuries B.C."

- Paul Unschuld

Huangdi neijing was written around the same time when its authors were convinced by the above set of fairly understandable natural laws.

READING TEXT

CHAPTER 2

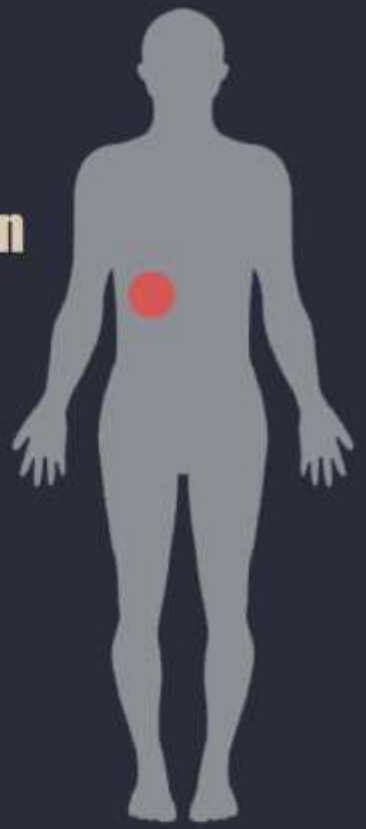
COMPREHENSIVE DISCOURSE ON REGULATING THE SPIRIT [IN ACCORDANCE WITH] THE QI OF THE FOUR [SEASONS]

四氣調神大論

CHAPTER 2

SPRING

- **Maintain Generation**

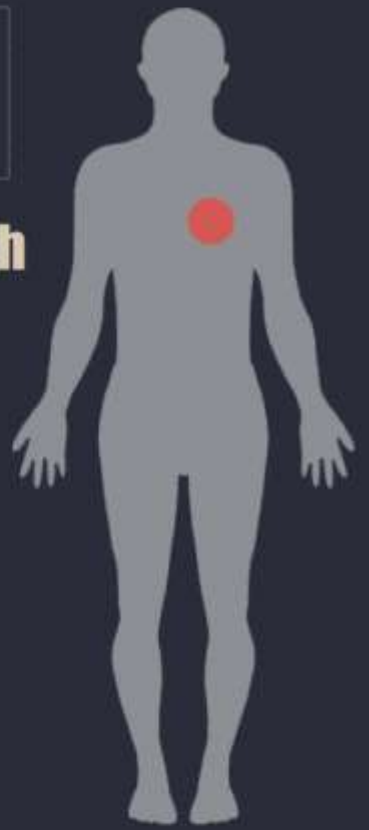


The three months of spring, they denote effusion and spreading.
Heaven and earth together generate life; the myriad beings flourish.
Go to rest late at night and rise early.
Move through the courtyard with long strides.
Dishevel the hair and relax the physical appearance,
thereby cause the mind [to orient itself on] life.
Give life and do not kill.
Give and do not take.
Reward and do not punish.
This is correspondence with the qi of spring and it is the way to nourish life. Opposing it harms the liver.
In summer, this causes changes to cold,
and there is little to support growth.

CHAPTER 2

SUMMER

- **Maintain Growth**



The three months of summer, they denote opulence and blossoming.
The qi of heaven and earth interact and the myriad beings bloom and bear fruit.
Go to rest late at night and rise early.
Never get enough of the sun.
Let the mind have no anger.
Stimulate beauty and have your elegance perfected.
Cause the qi to flow away.
As if that what you loved were located outside.
This is correspondence with the qi of summer and it is the way to nourish growth.
Opposing it harms the heart.
In autumn this causes jie and malaria,and there is little to support gathering.
Multiple disease [develops] at winter solstice.

CHAPTER 2

AUTUMN

- **Maintain Balance**

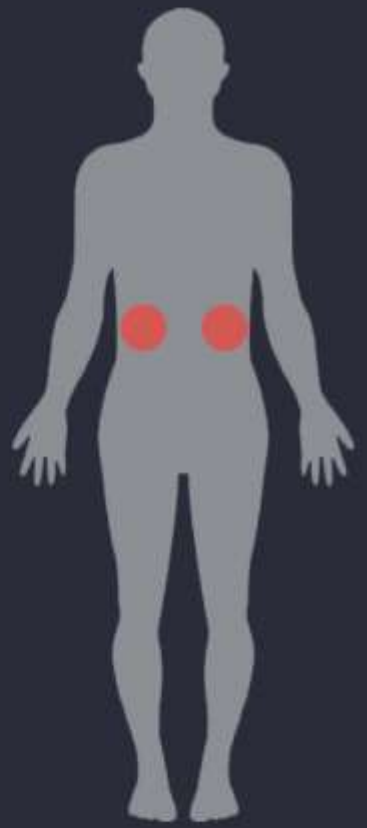
The three months of autumn, they denote taking in and balance.
The qi of heaven becomes tense. The qi of the earth becomes bright.
Go to rest early and rise early,
Get up together with the chicken.
Let the mind be peaceful and tranquil,
so as to temper the punishment carried out in autumn.
Collect the spirit qi and cause the autumn qi to be balanced.
Do not direct your mind to the outside and cause the lung qi to be clear.
This is correspondence with the qi of autumn and it is the way to nourish gathering.
Opposing it harms the lung.
In winter this causes outflow of [undigested] food and there is little to support storage.



CHAPTER 2

WINTER

- To Preserve



The three months of winter,they denote securing and storing.
The water is frozen and the earth breaks open.
Do not disturb the yang [qi].
Go to rest early and rise late.
You must wait for the sun to shine.
Let the mind enter a state as if hidden, {as if shut in}
as if you had secret intentions;as if you already had made gains.
Avoid cold and seek warmth and do not [allow sweat] to flow away through the skin.
This would cause the qi to be carried away quickly.
This is correspondence with the qi of winter and it is the way of nourishing storage.
Opposing it harms the kidneys.
In spring this causes limpness with receding [qi]. and there is little to support generation.

… …

If one acts contrary to the qi of **spring**, then the **minor yang** does not promote generation. The **liver** qi changes internally.

If one acts contrary to the qi of **summer**, then the **major yang** does not stimulate growth. The **heart** qi is empty internally.

If one acts contrary to the qi of **autumn**, then the **major yin** does not collect. The **lung** qi burns and there is fullness.

If one acts contrary to the qi of **winter**, then the **minor yin** does not store. The **kidney** qi is turbid and in the depth.



… …

Hence, yin [qi], yang [qi], and the four seasons,
they constitute end and begin of the myriad beings,
they are the basis of death and life.
Opposing them results in catastrophe and harms life.
If one follows them, severe diseases will not emerge.
This is called “to achieve the Way.”
As for the Way,
the sages practice it;
the stupid wear it [for decoration only].
If one follows yin and yang, then life results;
if one opposes them, then death results.
If one follows them, then order results;
if one opposes them, then disorder results.
(To act contrary to what is appropriate, this is opposition.
This is called inner obstruction.)



Conclusion of Chapter Two

是故圣人不治已病，治未病，不治已乱，治未乱，此之谓也。
夫病已成而后药之，乱已成而后治之，譬犹渴而穿井，斗而铸锥，不亦晚乎?

Hence, [when it is said] “the sages did not treat those already ill, but treated those not yet ill,

They did not put in order what was already in disorder, but put in order what was not yet in disorder,”

then this means just the same.

Now, when drugs are employed for therapy only after a disease has become fully developed,

when [attempts at] restoring order are initiated only after disorder has fully developed,

this is as if a well were dug when one is thirsty,

and as if weapons were cast when the fight is on.

Would this not be too late, too?

- Underlying Philosophy of *Su Wen* in *Huang di nei jing*

Combining the views of different schools, Su Wen relies exclusively on natural law as conceptualised in “Yin” & “ Yang" and Five Agents doctrines to define health and disease, and repeatedly emphasises personal responsibility for the length and quality of one's life.